

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE WASHINGTON, D.C. 20250

DEPARTMENTAL REGULATION	NUMBER: DR 5600-006
SUBJECT: Sustainable Operations	DATE: August 5, 2026
OPI: Office of Property and Environmental Management (OPEM)	EXPIRATION DATE: August 5, 2031

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1. PURPOSE

This Departmental Regulation (DR) establishes the United States Department of Agriculture's (USDA) policy for sustainable operations of real property, personal property, and acquisitions.

2. SPECIAL INSTRUCTIONS/CANCELLATIONS

- a. This DR supersedes Section 5b, *Sustainable Operations*, of DR 5600-005, *Environmental Management*, dated September 24, 2012.
- b. A forthcoming revision to DR 5600-005, *Environmental Management* will supersede the balance of that directive.

- c. This DR is in effect upon issue and remains in effect until it is superseded or expires.

3. SCOPE

This DR applies to all USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices involved in acquisitions as well as those responsible for the design, construction, leasing, operations, maintenance, or disposition of real or personal property.

4. BACKGROUND

- a. Multiple statutes require Federal agencies to reduce their environmental impacts, reduce energy and water use, increase the use of renewable energy, purchase sustainable products, and meet other related goals.
- b. USDA takes action to design and construct buildings, to conduct operations, and to procure, manage, and dispose of real and personal property, including fleet, sustainably. It does so to reduce direct and indirect impacts to the environment, increase operational efficiencies, and promote the health and well-being of USDA employees and visitors.

5. POLICY

- a. USDA complies with all Federal, state, and local requirements including laws, policies and E.O.s, as they apply to sustainable operations. These include energy, environmental, sustainable building, and procurement mandates.
- b. The USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices must, across their portfolios:
 - (1) Reduce building energy use intensity annually;
 - (2) Use renewable energy and consume energy efficiently;
 - (3) Reduce water use intensity;
 - (4) Manage stormwater effects;
 - (5) Use performance contracts to attain USDA energy and water goals;
 - (6) Sustainably design, construct, and operate new and existing buildings and landscaping, to protect the environment and human health, and ensure operational resiliency;

- (7) Track and report on actions to improve performance for energy, water, greenhouse gas emissions, costs, and for other metrics as required;
- (8) Consider building and site efficiencies in leasing actions;
- (9) Optimize space in owned and leased facility practices, in keeping with occupant safety and health requirements;
- (10) Use sustainable practices to manage and operate the USDA fleet and to reduce petroleum use;
- (11) Prevent waste and improve recycling practices;
- (12) Comply with all Federal solid, hazardous, and toxic waste disposal mandates;
- (13) Follow required purchasing preferences and acquire, use, and dispose of products and services, including electronics, sustainably through the lifecycle; and
- (14) Use Environmental Management Systems (EMS) where appropriate. Implement and maintain effective management tools.

6. ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

- a. The USDA Assistant Secretary for Administration (ASA) holds primary responsibility for USDA sustainable practices. The ASA will:
 - (1) Represent USDA on Federal interagency sustainability steering committees;
 - (2) Chair periodic USDA Sustainable Operations Council (SOC) meetings;
 - (3) Develop a strategic USDA process to ensure that functions and programs include sustainability goals;
 - (4) Ensure that USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices integrate sustainable practices into all policies, programs, plans and accountability wherever relevant;
 - (5) Prepare and distribute USDA Mission Area, agency, and staff office scorecards to recognize goal attainment and identify areas for improvement; and
 - (6) Provide the USDA reports and plans to the Office of Management and Budget (OMB), Council on Environmental Quality (CEQ), and lead Federal agencies.
- b. The Director of Office of Property and Environmental Management (OPEM) will:

- (1) Lead USDA sustainable operations programs;
- (2) Develop goals, objectives, and targets for SOC approval;
- (3) Direct staff to develop and carry out policies;
- (4) Issue data calls and direct staff to write, review, analyze, and submit required Mission Area, agency, and staff office reports;
- (5) Monitor progress in meeting the USDA goals; and
- (6) Assist, guide, and direct USDA Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices to set policies and practices specified in this DR.

c. Mission Area, Agency, and Staff Office Heads will:

- (1) Participate in the USDA SOC;
- (2) Identify Mission Area, agency, or staff office liaisons to prepare the Mission Area, agency, or staff office's annual reports, plans, and OMB scorecard data;
- (3) Integrate sustainable operations within each Mission Area, agency, or staff office's strategic planning, budgeting process, and, if present, EMS;
- (4) Identify, develop, and complete relevant Mission Area, agency, or staff office activities, policies, plans, procedures, and practices;
- (5) Specify Mission Area, agency, or staff office goals, schedules, milestones, and means to achieve the USDA goals as well as to align with statutory and regulatory requirements;
- (6) Attain energy, water, sustainable buildings, low impact development, waste management, electronics stewardship, procurement, fleet management and all other sustainable practices program goals; and
- (7) Track Mission Area, agency, or staff office progress towards meeting these goals.

d. Employees will:

Follow practices and take actions to achieve their Mission Area, agency, or staff office's sustainable operations objectives and targets in keeping with the Federal and USDA goals and policies.

7. INQUIRIES

Direct any questions regarding this policy to the OPEM Environmental Management Division Chief, Room 1075, South Building, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, D.C. 20250.

-END-

APPENDIX A

ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

ASA	Assistant Secretary for Administration
CEQ	Council on Environmental Quality
CFR	Code of Federal Regulations
DR	Departmental Regulation
EISA	Energy Independence and Security Act of 2007
EMS	Environmental Management System
E.O.	Executive Order
EPAct	Energy Policy Act of 2005
EPA	U.S. Environmental Protection Agency
ISO	International Organization for Standardization
P.L.	Public Law
NECPA	National Energy Conservation Policy Act
OMB	Office of Management and Budget
OPEM	Office of Property and Environmental Management
RCRA	Resource Conservation and Recovery Act
SOC	Sustainable Operations Council
U.S.C.	United States Code
USDA	United States Department of Agriculture

APPENDIX B

DEFINITIONS

Agency. Organizational units of the Department, other than staff offices as defined below, whose heads report to officials within the Office of the Secretary, Deputy Secretary, Under Secretaries, Assistant Secretaries, and Assistant to the Secretary. (Source: USDA, [DR 0100001](#), *Departmental Directives System*)

Biobased product. As determined by the U.S. Department of Agriculture, a commercial or industrial product, other than food or feed, that is composed, in whole or significant part, of biological products, including renewable domestic agricultural materials, renewable chemicals and forestry materials. Learn more at www.biopreferred.gov.

Environmental Management System (EMS). A framework that helps an organization achieve its environmental goals through consistent review, evaluation, and continual improvement of its environmental performance. An EMS uses the “Plan-Do-Check-Act” framework for continual improvement. The most widely accepted model is the International Organization for Standardization’s ISO 14001 standard (current edition).

Greenhouse Gases (GHG). Gases that trap heat in the atmosphere. These gases affect processes of the ocean and atmosphere. The principal GHGs that enter the atmosphere because of human activities include carbon dioxide, methane, nitrous oxide, and certain fluorinated gases.

Mission Area. A group of agencies with related functions that report to the same Under or Assistant Secretary. Research, Education, and Economics (REE) is an example of a Mission Area. (Source: USDA, DR 0100-001)

OMB Scorecard. An OMB developed tool. The CEQ and OMB use scorecards to evaluate agency progress in meeting sustainable operations goals specified in statutes and E.O.s.

Renewable Energy. Energy generated from solar, wind, biomass, landfill gas, ocean (including tidal, wave, current, and thermal), geothermal, municipal solid waste, or new hydroelectric generation capacity achieved from increased efficiency or additions of new capacity at an existing hydroelectric project. (Source: [42 United States Code \(U.S.C.\) § 15852\(b\)\(2\)](#), *Renewable energy*).

Staff Office. Departmental administrative offices whose heads report to officials within the Office of the Secretary. (Source: USDA, DR 0100-001)

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Sustainability. Within an environmental, societal, and economic context, the capacity to create and maintain conditions under which humans and nature can exist in productive harmony. Sustainable development meets the needs of current generations without harming the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. (Sources: The Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and the Brundtland Commission)

APPENDIX C

AUTHORITIES AND REFERENCES

[7 Code of Federal Regulations \(CFR\) Part 2](#), *Delegations of Authority by the Secretary of Agriculture and General Officers of the Department*

[10 CFR Part 433](#), *Energy Efficiency Standards for the Design and Construction of New Federal Commercial and Multi-Family High-Rise Residential Buildings*

[10 CFR Part 435](#), *Energy Efficiency Standards for the Design and Construction of New Federal Low-Rise Residential Buildings*

[10 CFR Part 436](#), *Federal Energy Management and Planning Programs*

[42 U.S.C. § 15852\(b\)\(2\)](#), *Renewable energy*

[48 CFR Chapter 1](#), *Federal Acquisition Regulation*

Agricultural Act of 2014 (the 2014 Farm Bill), [Public Law \(P.L.\) 113-79](#),

Agriculture Improvement Act of 2018 (the 2018 Farm Bill), [P.L. 115-334](#), December 20, 2018

Council on Environmental Quality, [CEQ-OFS-2020-1](#), *Guiding Principles for Sustainable Federal Buildings and Associated Instructions*, December 2020

Energy Independence and Security Act of 2007 (EISA), [42 U.S.C. § 17001](#), December 2007

Energy Policy Act of 2005 (EPAAct), [42 U.S.C. § 6361](#), August 2005

[E.O. 12088](#), *Federal Compliance with Pollution Control Standards*, October 13, 1978

Federal Register, [Vol. 84, No. 86, Page 19056](#), *Instructions for Implementing Efficient Federal Operations Executive Order (E.O.) 13834*, April 30, 2019

General Services Administration, *Federal Management Regulation*, [41 CFR Part 102-36](#), *Disposition of Excess Personal Property, and Federal Management Regulation*

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General Services Administration, Federal Management Regulation , [41 CFR Part 102-37](#),
Donation of Surplus Personal Property

National Energy Conservation Policy Act of 1978 (NECPA), [P.L. 95-619](#), November 9, 1978

Pollution Prevention Act of 1990, [42 U.S.C. §13101 et seq.](#)

Resource Conservation and Recovery Act of 1976 (RCRA), [42 U.S.C. § 6962](#)

USDA, *Agriculture Property Management Regulation* [110-34](#), *Motor Vehicle Management*

USDA, [BioPreferred](#) website

USDA, [DR 0100-001](#), *Departmental Directives System*, January 4, 2018

USDA, [DR 1058-001](#), *Sustainable Operations Council*, December 21, 2021

USDA, [DR 1070-001](#), *U.S. Department of Agriculture Policy Statement on Climate Change Adaptation*, May 26, 2021

USDA, [DR 1620-003](#), *Facilities and Space Management*, March 31, 2021

USDA, [DR 5100-004](#), *Real Property Management*, February 9, 2023

USDA, [DR 5600-005](#), *Environmental Management*, February 28, 2022